



Nation

PARTY SPOKESPERSONS

Prime Time PUNDITS

They strike the right pose, wear the correct colours and choose the appropriate words for their 15 seconds of electoral fame

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

Abhishek Manu Singhvi will never allow a camera inside his house. So every evening when at least five OB vans are parked outside his Niti Bagh home, he will be parked on the verandah. Prakash Javadekar, who picks up his eyecatching kurtas from Fabindia, is very particular about a spot of make-up before going in for a television debate. Amar Singh will never agree to a discussion if Salman Khurshid is part of a panel. Sitaram Yechury requires at least four days prior notice and a request on fax. And Sushma Swaraj's office will always enquire about the colour of the sari she should wear before setting out for the studio.

Welcome to the world of party spokespersons, television's prime time superstars, much in demand during Election 2009, and trying hard to match their rhetoric with the heated words from the heat and dust of canvassing. It's a world which has grown by leaps and bounds since 2004, with news channels now numbering over 60, and television panels resembling identification parades. But in spite of competition from journalists doubling as party strategists and lawyers behaving like party apologists, Election 2009 has reaffirmed the star status of some spokespersons and created new soundbyte heroes. These are men and women, as one guest coordinator for a channel puts it, whose "audio and video are both good".

And they work at it. So Balbir Punj, second time Rajya Sabha member

who was in the ABVP and was inducted as a spokesperson because he is close to L.K. Advani, will always dress in the Team Advani staple: one of his five Jawahar jackets. Jayanthi Natarajan has an endless collection of south Indian silk saris while Ravi Shankar Prasad favours kurta pyjamas—though he's not obsessed with ikat like his compatriot Rajiv Pratap Rudy. Even some of the juniors have their ticks: BJP's Nalin Kohli gets his blindingly white chikan kurtas straight from Lucknow while Jyotiraditya Scindia dresses exactly like his late father.

The spokesperson's work is never done. Singhvi's mornings are spent in a difficult contest between the daily newspapers and his constitutional. Punj spends two hours every morning reading 18 Hindi and English dailies while Ashwani Kumar spent a considerable time after the last general elections boning up on his Hindi, consulting a dictionary, and sometimes even calling up friends when he's stuck for a word.

They have also become particular. So Kapil Sibal will usually step into the studio for a debate only if his opponent is Arun Jaitley. Otherwise, he prefers to join the discussion from his Teen Murti Lane home. Javadekar invites television crews to his office, usually turning in three to four back-to-back chats within 8 p.m. and 10 p.m., a far

CONGRESS

Abhishek Manu Singhvi

STYLE Top of the pops, available, affable and usually error-free

FAVOURITE PHRASE *Ulta chor kotwal ko dante*



Jayanthi Natarajan

STYLE Steely schoolmarm, who can snap when required

FAVOURITE PHRASE Let me complete my sentence, please



BJP

Ravi Shankar Prasad

STYLE Cheerful and easy, though the laugh is alarming

FAVOURITE PHRASE *Kshama kijiye*. Or, Let me tell you, my friend.



Balbir Punj

STYLE Takes hard Hindutva line but doesn't lose his cool

FAVOURITE PHRASE Begins every answer, even if in English, with "dekhiye"



cry from the 2004 elections, he says, when he would carry his dinner with him on his way to various studios, as "I am an early eater". Punj's Dr Rajendra Prasad Road living room acts as occasional television studio. And Kumar has two libraries at home where TV cameras set up position every